

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

FADE IN:

1 INT. GIRL'S ROOM - AFTERNOON

SUN shines through a tiny window. Little bits of DUST and fluff float by.

Girl's room is messy, dishevelled, just like her; slumped over a CHROMEBOOK in pyjama pants. Several cups on the floor, packages, indeterminate cloth and plastic objects. The floor is nowhere to be seen. Girl types avidly, but only on the arrow keys.

CLOSE-UP. CHROMEBOOK

A useless game -- 2048. Y'know, the one where you add numbers to make bigger numbers.

KNOCKS can be heard in the distance. The screen flashes with a tan-coloured 'Game Over'.

GIRL

Agh! What do you want?

Pythagoras enters tentatively, still wearing the same robes as last episode -- but they do seem cleaner. Maybe he's learned the art of the washing machine.

PYTHAGORAS

Χαῖρε!

Girl looks back, unimpressed. Her screen still faces him. Discreetly, she starts a new game.

GIRL

I'm busy, Pythagoras.

PYTHAGORAS

(Serious as he'll ever be)
That wicked device is emanating
ominous energy! I felt it all
the way from the kitchens and
knew at once that you were in
danger.

He approaches and points directly at 2048.

PYTHAGORAS (cont.d)

Why were those numbers dancing?
Numbers aren't supposed to
dance.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

GIRL

Ohhh. I'm not supposed to be on
that game either.

Girl switches tabs to a "PSYCHOLOGY STUDY QUIZLET." She
doesn't seem too panicked. It's not like a
potentially-imaginary friend (who somehow has a corporeal
form) will hold her accountable... Will he?

GIRL (cont.d)

Sorry. Mmm. Homework. IB HL...
Psych-o-lo-gy... begins now-

PYTHAGORAS

(visibly distressed)
WAIT! WAIT! DO NOT DARE!

Pythagoras skitters forward, but warily -- like the
CHROMEBOOK is a dangerous monster.

PYTHAGORAS

There is an even darker energy
cascading, simply exploding from
the surface of *that* one.

He points at the QUIZLET, titled "BANDURA ET. AL". Its
maker has gracefully attached a picture of Bobo the
Clown.

Girl quirks an eyebrow.

GIRL

"That one" is about kids beating
up inflatable clown dolls... Fun
stuff.

An emphatic gasp from Pythagoras. He raises his hands as
if to shield himself.

PYTHAGORAS

Oh, I am *clearly* sound in my
judgments.

GIRL

(nonplussed)
Fun study. If kids see someone
beating the hell out of a clown,
they'll start doing it too.
Social cognitive theory or
whatever.

PYTHAGORAS

Terrible... Malicious... Evil... Must
be stopped at once.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

Girl has no idea what he's on, but wouldn't mind getting some too. Leisurely, she copies-and-pastes some bits from the QUIZLET into a new tab titled "PSYCH STUDY DOC :(".

GIRL

Yeah... Homework is pretty evil.

PYTHAGORAS

Not just "home-work", my troubled friend! A device that produces such corrupt knowledge surely mustn't be conducive to enlightenment.

GIRL

I'm good with no enlightenment.
A Level 6 would be nice, though.

Pythagoras' turn to be confused. As if he'd know anything about the IB grading system.

Assuming this has something to do with her state of existence, he scans the room.

PAN ACROSS FLOOR. What a mess.

His grimace speaks for itself -- half "my school would never allow this", half "what are these strange objects?".

PYTHAGORAS

(fumbling with a Lego piece he found on the floor)
At this rate, you won't even attain whatever a "Level 2" means.

GIRL

Ouch.

PYTHAGORAS

Look, my friend -- can you even remember what a...

Pythagoras squints at her screen. One name on the document happens to be "Loftus".

PYTHAGORAS (cont.d)

...Law-fatooz is? Are you aware of the Law-fatooz?

GIRL

A huh?

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

Pythagoras squints harder. He's sure it says something.

PYTHAGORAS

...Law-fatoos.. Pah...
Law-fatoos-pah. What would you
happen to know about *that*?

GIRL

Huh??

At this, Pythagoras gasps. The worst has befallen her.

PYTHAGORAS

μᾶ τὸν Ἀπόλλωνα! It has wiped
your mind! The great
technological evil; plague of
modern society...

GIRL

(as realisation dawns on her)
Oh... Did you mean Loftus and
Palmer?

Pythagoras shakes his head "no".

Girl smiles a little, knowing she's right. At least she remembers something about psychology -- enough to correct him. That's a win.

GIRL (cont.d)

To be fair, devices aren't
always a plague. They're useful
sometimes... For games and stuff.

Pythagoras shakes his head again, this time more passionately. The beard shakes too.

PYTHAGORAS

You must part from that machine
at ONCE. I said I would help you
-- I said I had a solution --
but you must *listen* to *recover*.

If she won't take charge of her own destiny, he'll go downstairs and consume all the coconut rolls in the observable universe.

GIRL

(weakly protesting. very weakly)
But all my coursework is on it...
And my last therapist said I
shouldn't procrastinate with
"wellness breaks"...

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

PYTHAGORAS

(chanting)

Shut it off! Shut it off!

GIRL

If I shut this thing off, I'll
never get it done-

PYTHAGORAS

Deprive yourself of true
intellect no longer!

Girl looks convinced already. It didn't take much. It took almost nothing. 2048 was getting boring, anyway... And menial schoolwork is a roadblock that prevents creative children from taking over the world.

GIRL

Not a bad idea.

Pythagoras grins.

GIRL

But before I do this, give me
one good reason-

(beat)

No, it doesn't even have to be
good, just give me a reason. I'm
in need of a wellness break.

PYTHAGORAS

One reason... Ah! In order to gain
a truer sense of so-called
psychology, you must examine and
annotate real literature instead
of this inharmonious, impure,
soulless, *bean-adjacent* rubbish.

Girl opens her mouth, then closes it. She'll ignore the last bit.

GIRL

...I'll take it.

PYTHAGORAS

Ineffable.

Is that his version of "Yay"? Girl can't tell. Regardless, she has an idea. She rises from her dungeon.

GIRL

As a matter of fact... I *do* have
"real" literature somewhere
around the house. Just let me
find it.

DISSOLVE TO:

2 INT. KITCHEN TABLE - AFTERNOON

Girl plops a hefty-looking green book on the table. It's 500 pages long and a little tattered, with garish yellow letters that spell out "DSM-III". It smells old and looks the part too.

GIRL
Here we are!

Next, she deposits a smaller and newer piece of writing -- an IB Psychology textbook.

GIRL (cont.d)
Aaaand here.

Pythagoras stands over both like an eminent wizard, stroking his beard. He doesn't seem qualified to judge them, but he makes faces anyway.

GIRL (cont.d)
Found this bad boy,
(pointing to the DSM)
At the thrift store last month.
Some psychologist must've died
and left it. It's funny,
actually... The worse they are,
the longer they live for. This
one guy -- he, uhh, shoved a
bunch of Stanford students into
a prison simulation... He's
90-something and still kicking.
Crazy.

PYTHAGORAS
(seriously thinking)
The owner of this tome must have
been a good man, then.

GIRL
Perfect for us to learn from.

Curiosity piqued, Pythagoras picks up the DSM-III and sniffs the cover. He places it down immediately -- smells like a geriatric dog.

GIRL
What'd you do that for?

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

PYTHAGORAS

(horrified)

As I neared the cover, I slowly
began to sense an aura about it
-- a foreboding aura... I've never
felt this way since irrational
numbers!

Girl thinks he's joking and plays along with the bit. She
should know better.

GIRL

(mischievously)

Oh, what you're about to see is
much worse than the square root
of one. All the tortured souls
of undiagnosed high school
students are trapped in there.

PYTHAGORAS

Truly?

GIRL

(shrugging)

Let's see.

As Girl slowly, dramatically begins to open the DSM-III,
Pythagoras stands behind her and prays. His fingers are
crossed, he mutters something in Ancient Greek, and his
entire body braces for an invisible explosion.

DRAMATIC MUSIC plays... Tension you could cut with a knife...
Then everything crashes abruptly.

Girl opens the manual... Pythagoras cowers...
Lo and behold... A normal book!

GIRL

Safe!

Pythagoras clutches his heart, trying to "whew"
inconspicuously, but Girl turns around with concern. As
per usual, she ignores him and flips through.

GIRL

This was a real steal. There are
even bits in between from the
original owner... Some Harold J.
guy.

Girl beckons Pythagoras to look as she flips through the
pages. Dust comes off them.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

GIRL (cont.d)

Look, here's a sudoku page
trapped in the Personality
Disorders section -- it says:
(read slowly)
"Patient thinks I am writing
notes. Actually, I am beating my
record. 100% APD. Or BPD. or
PAPD.. Or SPD. Or the other
APD." Ha.

Pythagoras tilts his head. These acronyms mean nothing to
him -- he only knows about the purification of the soul.

GIRL (cont.d)

And here's one on the first
page: "Freud was right."
Oh! And here -

It's a likely-horrifying annotation in the Psychosexual
disorders section. Girl goes quiet.

GIRL

(disgusted)
Never mind. I hate old men.

Pythagoras looks offended.

GIRL

Not *you*!

PYTHAGORAS

I did not think so. I am still
quite youthful.

A beat. Maybe two beats. Girl looks back at Pythagoras,
who is very clearly aged. He has wrinkles. Grayish hair.
Knobby knees.

GIRL

Yup. Not a day over 70.
Aaanyway... it's an interesting
book, but pretty outdated. Even
the guy who owned it was an
old-timer.

PYTHAGORAS

Outdated, you say?

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

GIRL

(excited to teach an ancient man
something new)
Mhm! Psychology is a road paved
in blood, or whatever they say.
Now we stand on better
knowledge, but way back when...
Not good. Not good at all.

Pythagoras motions for her to pass the book. Carefully,
like he's holding a bomb, he sits down and goes through
it.

PYTHAGORAS

Such is the way of nature... We
have strayed far from ultimately
uniting with the cosmos.

GIRL

..Sure!

Girl notices that he is "locked in", as the kids call it.
She feels pressured to do the same. She carefully takes
her IB PSYCHOLOGY TEXTBOOK -- the forgotten one -- and
takes a seat at the table opposite him.

They read in silence for a while. This almost seems
serious.

An indefinite amount of time passes.
PEACEFUL or OLD-TIMEY MIME music. Your choice.

FREEZE FRAMES:

Girl sits with her legs propped up.
Pythagoras eats some bread as he reads.
Other usual frames.
Girl falls asleep.
Pythagoras throws a dinner roll at her head.
Other such frames follow, like a stop-motion animation.
Music stops.

CUT TO:

About ten minutes later, Pythagoras has a great idea.

PYTHAGORAS

Attention, my friend! Have you
perhaps had a... Recent loss of
interest in pastimes?

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

GIRL
(busy with her own reading)
Yeah, always.

PYTHAGORAS
Do you neglect avocations that
were previously a source of
pleasure?

GIRL
(not listening)
Yuup. Right on.

PYTHAGORAS
Do you experience recurrent
feelings of inadequacy?

GIRL
(actually listening, this time)
Quite often... What's this about?

Pythagoras' little, wrinkled forehead peeks out from
behind the DSM-III. His eyes dart away furtively, then he
hides himself.

PYTHAGORAS
Nothing in particular.

FREEZE FRAMES:

More seemingly peaceful reading. Music returns.
In early frames, Pythagoras observes Girl -- scanning her
expressions for something.
In the last frames, he throws another roll at her head.
Music stops.

CUT TO:

Pythagoras' head appears again.

GIRL
OW! What was that for?

PYTHAGORAS
(spoken very rapidly)
Do you experience diminished
productivity at work?

GIRL
School, but yes. You hurt my
head, by the way.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

PYTHAGORAS

Apologies. Do you avoid
situations in which you may be
scrutinised by others?

GIRL

Don't we all?

PYTHAGORAS

...Interesting. Very interesting
indeed.

GIRL

It's not that int-

He disappears as he comes; shrouded in mystery and
possible senility. The book isn't a good facial covering.

GIRL (cont.d)

Oookay.

FREEZE FRAMES:

Music returns, but **faster**.

Some peaceful reading frames interspersed with
interrogation.

Pythagoras seems to be asking Girl more questions. At
first, she seems to be replying.

In each subsequent frame, however, her expression grows
more and more disgruntled. A mixture of that and
confusion.

After one last peaceful frame, he bothers her again.
The very final frame depicts Girl rising from her seat --
mouth open, about to protest.

Music record-scratches.

CUT TO:

Girl snatches the DSM-III from Pythagoras' hands. He
appears offended.

GIRL

What're you doing with that
thing? I thought you wanted me
to study from paper. Here I am,
studying from paper, and you're
bothering me every ten seconds!

PYTHAGORAS

Unfounded bouts of anger. That's
a twelfth.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

GIRL

A twelfth *what?*

PYTHAGORAS

Apparent confusion... That settles it!

Suddenly, Girl realises what he's doing. This idiot is going through the DSM like a shopping list and he's about to-

PYTHAGORAS

(clearing his throat)
Ahem. According to my newfound wisdom, you have...
(beat)
Cyclothymic Disorder, Dysthymic Disorder, Social Phobia, Simple Phobia, Hypochondriasis, Somatization Disorder, Adjustment Disorder, Major Depressive Disorder, *Minor* Depressive Disorder, Typical Anxiety Disorder, and Atypical Anxiety Disorder
Oh, and Conduct Disorder.

Girl's mouth hangs open. She wants to speak, but the words won't come out. Instead, she takes a deep breath -- in, out, whew -- and runs her hands through her hair. Pythagoras has run out of coconut rolls.

GIRL

That's... Not how anything works.

PYTHAGORAS

(offended)
Explain, then -- if you are so *high* and *mighty*.

GIRL

First of all, don't call me high and mighty. Second of all, fake Ancient Greek men can't invade homes and decide to become practising psychologists.

PYTHAGORAS

But I just have. I've done both things.

GIRL

No, no, no... Remember how I talked about the road "paved in blood"? *This* is the blood.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

Assuming she refers to actual blood, Pythagoras examines his hands. They're not red.

PYTHAGORAS

I see no blood.

GIRL

(seriously about to cry from frustration)
Listen -- there's no point in listing off what's wrong with me if... If you're not gonna make it better.
Say you have rabies, for example...

PYTHAGORAS

Why rabies? What kind of hypothetical is this?

GIRL

Just let me finish. If you've got any disease and you want to live, then diagnoses are important. But after that, you'll need treatment.

PYTHAGORAS

There is no cure for rabies.

GIRL

I...

Girl sinks back into her chair. She lets out a huff. She hasn't learned anything from the IB textbook, Pythagoras is a plague on her life, and he'll just keep ruining everything if she lets him.

PYTHAGORAS

...Are you alright, my friend?

GIRL

(beat)
NO. I can't do this anymore-

PYTHAGORAS

These fascinating tomes have taken a toll on you.

GIRL

-I can't do anything! I can't even get a competent imaginary friend, because whatever you are, you're... *fucked up*.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

Despite his limited awareness of English curse words, Pythagoras realises that Girl means business. She's pissed. He looks down at his lap like a cat who's just knocked over a precious vase.

They sit in reflective silence.

After a while, Girl rises.
He rises at the same time. This is an accident.

GIRL
(sighing)
Where are you going? Home?

PYTHAGORAS
...I am contractually obligated to
stay.

Pythagoras reaches into his pocket. Somehow, this ancient robe has pockets -- but, as he is about to reveal, its designer was particularly keen on interpretation.

He retrieves a wrinkled sheet of lined paper.
Old, ripped at the corners. Trash.
Unfolding the sheet reveals a familiar drawing.

Dated about 6 years ago. Very early middle school. Notes on the margins and some obscene scribbles:

"PYTHAGOREAN THEOREM - UGLY"
"I HATE MATH CLASS"
"MATH SUX"

Taking up most of the page is a surprisingly well-done drawing of Pythagoras; inspiration taken from Google. His outfit looks accurate, save for the pockets.

GIRL
That's...

Pythagoras grins.

PYTHAGORAS
Myself. By design, anyway. I am
only half the real thing.

Girl doesn't know what to say.
She stares at this reminder of her old self.
It's funny. And stupid. And sad.
Then, she takes the paper.

The paper evokes an old, buried memory.

EPISODE 2: THE DIAGNOSTIC MANUAL OF MENTAL ORDER

JUMP CUT TO:

3 INT. CLASSROOM - AUTUMN DAY

Leaves are falling outside the window. Red, brown, yellow. Change is on the horizon, whether Girl wants it or not.

A younger Girl sits at a desk near the back. As the teacher draws triangles, she scribbles furtive "notes". Her Chromebook -- an older model -- has a triangle-unrelated display.

Once she's done scribbling, she stares out the window, head down. Her reflection stares back.

DISSOLVE TO:

4 INT. DINING ROOM - LATE AFTERNOON

GIRL

(after an emotional pause)
If you think that pathos is
gonna stop me from kicking you
out...
(deep breath)
Okay, fine.

PYTHAGORAS

What do they say these days?
Takes one to know one?

GIRL

(amused)
You're an ass. And a coconut
roll freeloader.

PYTHAGORAS

I contribute to society in my
own positive way. And I can do
things. As a matter of fact,
I've already developed a new
treatment plan.

Girl is unimpressed. Her bar lays low; on the floor.

GIRL

That is...?

PYTHAGORAS

Wilderness therapy!

GIRL

Definitely not.

FADE OUT:

Next Episode:
Applied Ecology